

WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY, 1918–1939

KEY TOPIC 1: THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC, 1918–1929

Student Master Textbook • Core Knowledge, Disciplinary Enquiries & Archival Evidence



Plate 1: Potsdamer Platz and the Traffic Tower in Golden Twenties Berlin (c. 1924–1928)

Historical Primary Photograph

OFFICIAL PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION STRUCTURE & SYLLABUS MAPPING (OPTION 31: KT1)

Core syllabus coverage across all four key enquiries:

1. ORIGINS OF REPUBLIC, 1918–19

- Legacy of WW1: abdication of Kaiser, armistice and revolution, 1918–19.
- Setting up of Weimar Republic: National Assembly and new constitution.
- Strengths and weaknesses of new constitution (Proportional Representation, Article 48).

2. EARLY CHALLENGES, 1919–23

- Reasons for unpopularity: stab in the back (*Dolchstoßlegende*) and Versailles Treaty.
- Political challenges: Spartacist Uprising, Kapp Putsch, and political assassinations.
- Economic challenges: French occupation of Ruhr (1923), causes and effects of hyperinflation.

3. RECOVERY OF REPUBLIC, 1924–29

- Economic recovery: Stresemann, Rentenmark, Dawes Plan (1924), US loans, Young Plan (1929).
- Foreign policy: Locarno Treaties (1925), League of Nations (1926), Kellogg-Briand (1928).
- Impact on domestic political stability and reduced extremist support.

4. CHANGES IN SOCIETY, 1924–29

- Standard of living: changes in wages, housing, and 1927 unemployment insurance.
- Position of women: politics (voting, deputies), work (double-earners), leisure ('New Woman').
- Cultural changes: developments in architecture (Bauhaus), art (*Neue Sachlichkeit*), and cinema.

KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

Key Enquiry: Out of the ashes: How did the devastating legacy of the First World War forge the Weimar Republic, and were the democratic foundations of its new Constitution fatally flawed from the start? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE LEGACY OF THE FIRST WORLD WAR: A NATION ON THE BRINK

[1.1] By the autumn of 1918, Germany was physically, financially, and psychologically broken. The First World War had drained the nation's resources. Financially, the German government's debt had tripled from 50 billion marks in 1914 to 150 billion marks in 1918. Humanly, the cost was staggering: 2 million German soldiers had been killed and over 4 million wounded (roughly 55% of all German troops became casualties).

[1.2] Crucially, the home front was collapsing. The British naval blockade had prevented food and supplies from reaching Germany, resulting in the starvation of approximately 750,000 civilians. Disillusionment quickly turned to anger. The German public had been fed government propaganda promising imminent victory; when the reality of unavoidable defeat set in, society began to implode. Strikes rippled across the country, and the people turned their fury on their autocratic ruler, Kaiser Wilhelm II.

SOURCE A OFFICIAL PROCLAMATION

9 November 1918

Philipp Scheidemann Proclaims the Republic from the Reichstag Window

"The German people have won all along the line. What was old and rotten has collapsed; militarism is at an end! The Hohenzollerns have abdicated! Long live the German Republic! Ebert has been charged with forming a government... See to it that the new Republic is not endangered by anything. Long live the free German Republic!"

Spoken spontaneously from a window of the Reichstag in Berlin on the afternoon of 9 November 1918 to pre-empt communist leader Karl Liebknecht from proclaiming a Soviet Republic from the nearby royal palace.

HINGE QUESTION: Did Scheidemann's proclamation create a genuine democratic mandate, or did it expose the deep ideological divisions that doomed the Republic?

ACT 2 REVOLUTION FROM BELOW: MUTINY AND ABDICATION

[2.1] The breaking point occurred in late October 1918. The German naval command ordered a final, suicidal attack on the British Royal Navy. The sailors at the Kiel naval base refused to follow orders, triggering a widespread mutiny. This defiance spread like wildfire. Across Germany, workers and soldiers began setting up their own unofficial councils, seizing control of local governments in major cities.

[2.2] Realising that the army would no longer fight for him, and informed by the Allies that they would not negotiate peace with a military autocrat, Kaiser Wilhelm II bowed to the inevitable. On 9 November 1918, he abdicated and fled to exile in Holland.

[2.3] With the Kaiser gone, Berlin descended into chaos. To prevent a communist takeover by the radical Spartacists, Philipp Scheidemann, a leading member of the Social Democratic Party (SPD), rushed to a balcony of the Reichstag and proclaimed Germany a democratic republic.

[2.4] The following day, Friedrich Ebert (SPD) became Chancellor of a temporary government called the Council of People's Representatives. His most pressing task was ending the war. On 11 November 1918, his representative, Matthias Erzberger, signed the Armistice. While this ended the bloodshed, it was deeply unpopular. Because the German army had not been invaded and was still stationed in France, many Germans felt betrayed. A toxic myth was born: the *Dolchstoßlegende*. The democratic politicians who signed the Armistice were branded the 'November Criminals'. From day one, the new Republic was associated with surrender and national shame.

SOURCE B CONSTITUTIONAL CHARTER

11 August 1919

Articles 22 and 48 of the Weimar Constitution

"Article 22: The Reichstag shall be elected by universal, equal, direct and secret ballot by all men and women over twenty years of age, in accordance with the principles of proportional representation..."

Article 48: If public safety and order in the Reich are seriously disturbed or endangered, the Reich President may take the measures necessary to restore public safety and order, intervening if necessary with the aid of the armed forces."

Drafted by liberal jurist Hugo Preuss, the Constitution created Europe's most democratic franchise while simultaneously introducing the emergency decree loophole that ultimately enabled authoritarian rule.

HINGE QUESTION: Was Article 48 a necessary emergency safety valve for a fragile democracy, or a constitutional suicide pill?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.1

PROPORTIONAL REPRESENTATION

Electoral system where parties gain seats precisely proportional to national votes, causing coalition instability.

ARTICLE 48

Emergency constitutional clause allowing the President to rule by decree without parliamentary consent.

DOLCHSTOSSLEGENDE

The toxic right-wing myth that the German army was undefeated in the field but stabbed in the back by democratic politicians.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

EBERT-GROENER PACT

Secret pact where the army pledged loyalty to the civilian government in exchange for state autonomy and suppressing communism.

KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

ACT 3 FORGING A NEW DEMOCRACY: THE WEIMAR CONSTITUTION

[3.1] In January 1919, Germany held its first democratic elections. Because Berlin was still engulfed in violent political riots, the newly elected politicians met in the peaceful town of Weimar to draft the rules for how the country should be governed.

[3.2] The **Weimar Constitution** established a clear chain of power:

- **The President:** The Head of State, elected every 7 years by the people. He played no part in day-to-day politics but commanded the army and chose the Chancellor.
- **The Chancellor:** The Head of Government, who ran the country day-to-day. He needed the support of a majority of politicians in the **Reichstag** to pass laws.
- **The Electorate:** All men and women over the age of 20 had the right to vote.
- **Local Power:** The 18 local regions (*Länder*) kept their own local parliaments (and were represented nationally in the *Reichsrat*).

[3.3] **The Democratic Transition & Elections of January 1919:** Following the Kaiser's abdication on 9 November 1918, Friedrich Ebert formed a provisional six-man Council of People's Representatives (*Rat der Volksbeauftragten*). The council declared an immediate armistice, introduced the eight-hour working day, and scheduled national democratic elections for 19 January 1919. Despite violent street fighting and boycotts by communist radicals, over 30 million Germans voted—achieving an extraordinary 83% turnout that provided an overwhelming democratic mandate to convene the National Assembly and draft the Weimar Constitution.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE SECRET TELEPHONE AGREEMENT 10 November 1918

General Wilhelm Groener on the Ebert-Groener Pact

"On the evening of 10 November, I telephoned Friedrich Ebert in the Chancellery over our secret line... I informed him that the High Command placed itself at the disposal of his government. In return, the Field Marshal and I expected the government to support the officer corps in maintaining discipline, supply the army, and combat revolutionary Bolshevism with all vigor. Ebert accepted our offer of alliance with deep relief."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1871–1925



Friedrich Ebert

LEADER OF THE SPD & FIRST PRESIDENT OF THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC (1919–1925)

Steered Germany through imperial collapse, concluded the Armistice, and negotiated the democratic constitution while suppressing violent revolts.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Formed the provisional Council of People's Representatives on 10 November 1918 following the Kaiser's abdication.
- Forged the secret Ebert-Groener Pact with the Imperial Army to maintain public order and suppress communist insurrection.
- Convened the National Assembly at Weimar and signed the democratic Constitution into law on 11 August 1919.

ACT 4 EVALUATING THE CONSTITUTION: A FLAWED MASTERPIECE?

[4.1] On paper, the Weimar Constitution was one of the most progressive and democratic documents in the world. However, to a historian, it is clear that this document contained fatal structural flaws that would leave the Republic vulnerable to total collapse.

THE WEIMAR CONSTITUTION: STRENGTHS VS FATAL WEAKNESSES

DEMOCRACY

Universal Suffrage: Men and women over 20 gained the vote; direct proportional representation gave every vote equal weight.

Fatal Flaw: PR fragmented the Reichstag into dozens of splinter parties; no party ever won a majority, causing 20 coalition collapses.

EXECUTIVE

Checks & Balances: President, Chancellor, and Reichstag balanced powers; 18 *Länder* preserved regional self-government.

Fatal Flaw: Article 48 gave the President power to suspend civil rights and rule by decree, creating a constitutional route to dictatorship.

FEDERALISM

Regional Autonomy: The 18 *Länder* controlled local police, schools, and justice, preventing dictatorial centralisation in Berlin.

Fatal Flaw: Nationalist regional governments (e.g. Bavaria) frequently defied Berlin, providing safe havens for right-wing paramilitaries.

CIVIL RIGHTS

Progressive Charter: Guaranteed freedom of speech, assembly, and religious belief, with equal rights enshrined in law.

Fatal Flaw: The Republic failed to reform the imperial civil service and judiciary, leaving anti-democratic judges to subvert the rule of law.

CRITICAL MECHANISM: CONSTITUTIONAL FLAW PARLIAMENTARY DEMOCRACY • 1919

Proportional Representation & Coalition Paralysis

Under Weimar's pure proportional representation system, one seat in the Reichstag was awarded for every 60,000 votes cast nationally, with zero minimum threshold. This allowed dozens of small, radical splinter parties to enter parliament. Consequently, no single political party ever achieved an absolute majority between 1919 and 1933. Governments had to rely on unstable multi-party coalitions; between 1919 and 1933, Germany went through twenty different cabinets, with the average government collapsing after just eight months.

Strategic Legacy: Pure proportional representation fragmented parliamentary power, rendering democratic governance incapable of decisive action during national crises and eroding public confidence in the Reichstag.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE

WAS WEIMAR DOOMED FROM BIRTH?

Interpretation A: Structural Fatalism (Eberhard Kolb)

"Weimar democracy was crippled from its inception. Pure proportional representation guaranteed fragmented coalitions, while Article 48 planted a constitutional dictatorship mechanism that fatally compromised democratic governance."

Interpretation B: Elite Sabotage (Richard J. Evans)

"The constitution was a remarkably progressive charter. Its vulnerability stemmed not from legal text, but because conservative civil servants, judges, and military commanders remained in power, actively sabotaging democratic legitimacy."

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

Identify two reasons why Chancellor Max von Baden announced the Kaiser's abdication on 9 November 1918. [Recall: Kiel naval mutiny, British naval blockade, Allied refusal to negotiate with autocracy]

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS (PEEL):

Explain why the Ebert-Groener Pact created a dangerous dependency on the imperial officer corps. [Use causal connectives: Consequently... In return for... This undermined democratic control because...]

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

'The Weimar Constitution was a masterpiece of progressive democracy, not a flawed document.' How far do you agree? [Criteria: Compare universal franchise vs Article 48 emergency powers]

ENQUIRY 1.1 SYNTHESIS

KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

Key Enquiry: Surrounded by enemies: How did the Weimar Republic survive the traumatic birth of the Treaty of Versailles, violent uprisings from the extreme left and right, and the catastrophic economic collapse of 1923? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE TREATY OF VERSAILLES: A NATIONAL TRAUMA (JUNE 1919)

[1.1] The Weimar Republic was born into defeat, but the terms of the peace treaty nearly destroyed it entirely. When the German delegation travelled to the Palace of Versailles in France, they expected a fair treaty based on US President Woodrow Wilson's 'Fourteen Points'. Instead, they were barred from negotiating and forced to sign a **Diktat** on **28 June 1919**.

[1.2] For a historian, the terms can be broken down into four devastating categories:

- **Blame:** Article 231 (The War Guilt Clause) forced Germany to accept full and total blame for starting the war. This was the psychological blow that hurt the most.
- **Reparations:** Because they accepted the blame, Germany had to pay for all civilian damage. In 1921, this was fixed at a crippling £6.6 billion (132 billion gold marks).
- **Armed Forces:** The proud German military was gutted. The army was limited to 100,000 volunteers (no conscription). They were forbidden from having submarines, tanks, or an air force. The Rhineland (bordering France) was demilitarised.
- **Territory:** Germany lost 13% of its European territory (including the industrial powerhouse of Upper Silesia) and 100% of its overseas colonies.

The public reaction was pure outrage. The democratic politicians who signed it were branded the 'November Criminals', reinforcing the toxic *Dolchstoßlegende* ('stab in the back' myth). Right-wing nationalists seized on the Treaty as undeniable proof of betrayal, cementing deep hatred for the democratic Republic.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

January 1919

Government Machine-Gun Post on the Brandenburg Gate (Spartacist Uprising)



In January 1919, the communist Spartacus League launched an armed revolt in Berlin. Government troops and Freikorps units set up machine-gun positions behind the Quadriga atop the Brandenburg Gate to defend the government district before ruthlessly crushing the uprising and murdering Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the government's decision to deploy right-wing Freikorps to crush left-wing revolutionaries prove to be a fatal compromise for Weimar democracy?

ACT 2 THE THREAT FROM THE LEFT: THE SPARTACIST UPRISING (JANUARY 1919)

[2.1] Before the Treaty was even signed, the Republic faced a fight for its life. The **Spartacist League**, an extreme left-wing communist group led by Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht, wanted to trigger a Russian-style workers' revolution.

[2.2] On 6 January 1919, 100,000 communists took to the streets of Berlin, seizing control of key government buildings and telegraph offices. Chancellor Ebert's problem was that the regular army (the *Reichswehr*) was too weak to put down the revolt. In a desperate move, he deployed the **Freikorps**—heavily armed, right-wing ex-soldiers who despised communism. The Freikorps crushed the uprising with ruthless violence. Luxemburg and Liebknecht were arrested, beaten, and murdered. While the Republic survived, Ebert's reliance on right-wing thugs alienated the working class and proved that the democratic government could not maintain order on its own.

[2.3] By early 1920, the government tried to disband several Freikorps units to comply with the 100,000-man army limit dictated by Versailles. Outraged, 5,000 Freikorps marched on Berlin in March 1920, led by a right-wing nationalist named **Wolfgang Kapp**. They intended to overthrow the Republic and bring back the Kaiser.

[2.4] Ebert ordered the regular army to fire on the rebels, but the head of the army refused, stating: "*Reichswehr does not fire on Reichswehr*". The army was perfectly happy to shoot communists in 1919, but they would not shoot their right-wing brothers. Ebert and the government were forced to flee the capital. Kapp declared a new government.

[2.5] However, Kapp was defeated not by the military, but by the people. Ebert called on the workers of Berlin to launch a **General Strike**. Millions of workers downed tools. Gas, electricity, water, and transport ground to a halt. Realising he could not rule a paralysed country, Kapp fled to Sweden. The Republic survived again, but the key takeaway is clear: the Weimar government had virtually zero control over its own military.

SOURCE B ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

Autumn 1923

Stacks of Devalued Paper Currency in a Berlin Bank (1923)



Following the Franco-Belgian occupation of the Ruhr in January 1923 and the government's policy of passive resistance, the Reichsbank printed unbacked paper marks day and night. Here, bank clerks sit behind head-high stacks of bundled notes as a single loaf of bread rose to over 200 billion marks.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the hyperinflation crisis of 1923 permanently destroy the economic security and political faith of Germany's middle class?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.2

DIKTAT

A dictated peace; German term for Versailles because Germany was locked out of negotiations and forced to sign under threat of invasion.

FREIKORPS

Paramilitary units of fiercely anti-communist, nationalist demobilised soldiers organized to crush revolutionary uprisings.

PASSIVE RESISTANCE

Non-violent strike policy adopted by Ruhr miners in 1923, refusing to mine coal for French occupying forces.

HYPERINFLATION

Catastrophic currency collapse in 1923 where paper marks became worthless and prices rose out of control.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

ACT 3 THE CRISIS OF 1923: THE INVASION OF THE RUHR

[3.1] By late 1922, Germany's economy was failing, and they failed to send their scheduled reparations payment to France. The French believed the Germans were lying. In **January 1923**, French and Belgian troops invaded the **Ruhr**, Germany's most vital industrial region, to seize coal, steel, and manufactured goods as payment.

[3.2] The German government could not fight back militarily. Instead, they ordered the workers of the Ruhr to carry out **Passive Resistance**—to go on strike and refuse to produce anything for the French. The French responded brutally, bringing in their own workers, arresting those who resisted, and shooting over 100 Germans.

[3.3] **Judicial Bias & The Wave of Right-Wing Assassinations:** Between 1919 and 1922, right-wing terrorist death squads (such as Organisation Consul) carried out 376 political murders, assassinating prominent republicans including Finance Minister Matthias Erzberger and Foreign Minister Walther Rathenau. Weimar judges demonstrated blatant political bias: right-wing murderers served an average prison sentence of just four months, while left-wing offenders faced life imprisonment or execution, fatally compromising judicial legitimacy.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE THE PEACE TREATY

28 June 1919

Article 231 of the Treaty of Versailles (The War Guilt Clause)

"The Allied and Associated Governments affirm and Germany accepts the responsibility of Germany and her allies for causing all the loss and damage to which the Allied and Associated Governments and their nationals have been subjected as a consequence of the war imposed upon them by the aggression of Germany and her allies."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1871–1919



Rosa Luxemburg
CO-FOUNDER OF THE SPARTACUS LEAGUE & GERMAN COMMUNIST PARTY (KPD)

Brilliant Marxist theorist and orator who led the January 1919 Berlin insurrection against the moderate SPD government before being murdered by Freikorps officers.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Co-founded the radical anti-war Spartacus League in 1916, publishing underground revolutionary tracts.
- Demanded all power be transferred to Workers' and Soldiers' Councils rather than a parliamentary National Assembly.
- Arrested, beaten, and murdered alongside Karl Liebknecht by Freikorps soldiers on 15 January 1919, her body dumped in the Landwehr Canal.

ACT 4 THE CRISIS OF 1923: HYPERINFLATION

[4.1] Passive resistance created an apocalyptic economic crisis. The government was suddenly deprived of the wealth generated by the Ruhr, yet it still had to pay the wages of the striking workers. The government's solution was disastrous: they simply printed more paper money.

[4.2] Printing unbacked money completely destroyed its value, triggering **Hyperinflation**. Prices spiralled out of control daily, then hourly. A loaf of bread that cost 0.6 marks in 1918 cost 201 billion marks by November 1923. Workers had to be paid twice a day and carried their wages in wheelbarrows before prices went up again.

[4.3] The Winners and Losers of Hyperinflation:

- The Losers:** The middle classes were devastated. Anyone with savings in the bank, fixed pensions, or fixed incomes saw their life's wealth wiped out overnight.
- The Winners:** Anyone with loans or mortgages could pay off their debts with worthless paper money. Farmers benefited because the food they produced could be sold at highly inflated prices. Foreigners in Germany with foreign currency (like the US Dollar) could suddenly afford to buy businesses and property for a fraction of their real value.

By late 1923, the Republic was humiliated, bankrupt, and seemingly on the brink of total collapse.

FLASHPOINT IN FOCUS: ECONOMIC CATASTROPHE

THE RUHR OCCUPATION • 1923

The Ruhr Crisis & The Hyperinflation Spiral

When Germany defaulted on timber and coal deliveries in late 1922, French Prime Minister Raymond Poincaré ordered 60,000 French and Belgian troops to occupy the Ruhr industrial heartland in January 1923 to seize reparations in kind. Chancellor Wilhelm Cuno ordered passive resistance: workers went on general strike while French troops sealed off the region, cutting off 80% of German coal and iron production. To pay striking miners and keep the state functioning, the Reichsbank printed astronomical quantities of paper marks, triggering the catastrophic hyperinflation collapse.

Psychological Ruin: Middle-class Germans saw their life savings, pensions, and insurance policies utterly wiped out overnight. They never forgave the Weimar Republic for their humiliation, creating fertile soil for extremist recruitment.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE

THE TRAUMA OF 1923: PERMANENT SCAR OR RESILIENCE?

Interpretation A: Middle-Class Alienation (Detlev Peukert)

"Hyperinflation destroyed the moral foundation of the Republic. Middle-class citizens whose savings evaporated felt utterly betrayed by democracy, creating deep cynicism that made them fertile ground for later radicalization."

Interpretation B: Institutional Resilience (Mary Fulbrook)

"Despite extreme crises—Ruhr occupation, hyperinflation, and armed rebellions from left and right—the Republic did not collapse in 1923. The decisive introduction of the Rentenmark proved the state possessed vital resilience."

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

ENQUIRY 1.2 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

State two military terms imposed on Germany by the Treaty of Versailles. [Recall: 100,000 army limit, 6 battleships, demilitarised Rhineland, zero air force]

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS (PEEL):

Explain why General von Seeckt's declaration that 'Reichswehr does not fire on Reichswehr' exposed the fatal vulnerability of the Republic. [Use: This demonstrated that... Consequently...]

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

Assess whether the hyperinflation of 1923 was primarily caused by Versailles reparations or by reckless government spending. [Weigh: Passive resistance funding vs London ultimatum]

KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

Key Enquiry: Dancing on a volcano: Did Gustav Stresemann genuinely rescue the Weimar Republic from the ashes of 1923, or was Germany's 'Golden Age' built on quicksand? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE MAN OF THE HOUR: GUSTAV STRESEMANN

[1.1] In August 1923, at the height of the hyperinflation crisis, Gustav Stresemann became Chancellor. Though he was only Chancellor for 102 days before stepping down to become Foreign Minister (a post he held until his death in 1929), his impact was profound. Stresemann's ultimate goal was political stability. He believed that if he could fix the economy and restore Germany's respect on the world stage, the German people would unite behind moderate democratic parties and stop voting for extremists like the Communists and the Nazis.

[1.2] Stresemann's Policy of Fulfilment (*Erfüllungspolitik*): Stresemann recognised that Germany could not overturn Versailles through military defiance. Instead, he pioneered a pragmatic foreign policy of 'fulfilment': by scrupulously honouring treaty obligations, he won the trust of Britain and the US. At the 1924 London Conference, he secured the evacuation of Franco-Belgian occupation troops from the Ruhr. By appointing Dr Hjalmar Schacht to head the Reichsbank under the 1924 Bank Act, Stresemann anchored the new Reichsmark to gold and guaranteed strict central bank independence.

SOURCE A PRIVATE CORRESPONDENCE

September 1928

Gustav Stresemann on the Fragility of the Economic Recovery

"Our economic recovery is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is, in fact, dancing on a volcano. If our American creditors should ever decide to call in their short-term loans, a very large section of our industrial and commercial economy will collapse immediately."

From a private letter written by Foreign Minister Gustav Stresemann in autumn 1928, candidly acknowledging that Weimar's apparent golden prosperity was dangerously vulnerable to any sudden recall of Wall Street credit.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did Stresemann privately describe Germany's economic position as 'dancing on a volcano' despite rising industrial output?

ACT 2 ECONOMIC RECOVERY: FIXING THE CURRENCY

[2.1] Stresemann's first act was to call off the passive resistance in the Ruhr, getting Germans back to work. Next, he tackled hyperinflation. In November 1923, he destroyed the old, worthless currency and introduced a strictly controlled, temporary currency called the **Rentenmark**. Because Germany had no gold left, this currency was backed by the value of German industrial and agricultural land. People trusted it, and prices stabilised. In August 1924, control was handed over to the new Reichsbank, and a permanent currency, the **Reichsmark**, was introduced. The hyperinflation nightmare was officially over.

[2.2] To get the economy moving again, Stresemann negotiated with the USA.

- **The Dawes Plan (1924):** The USA agreed to loan Germany 800 million gold marks. Reparation payments were temporarily lowered to an affordable level, and the French agreed to leave the Ruhr. American money flooded into Germany, building new factories, houses, and roads.
- **The Young Plan (1929):** Stresemann successfully negotiated a massive reduction in the total reparations bill, dropping it from £6.6 billion to £2 billion, and gained an extra 59 years to pay it off. This meant the government could lower taxes, giving ordinary Germans more money to spend. However, right-wing nationalists (including Adolf Hitler) were furious, arguing that paying any reparations was a betrayal of Germany.

SOURCE B PRESS ANALYSIS

Late 1928

German Financial Press on Industrial Modernisation and the Dawes Plan

"Our national economy has finally achieved genuine stability. Through the Dawes Plan and massive American investment, our factories have been modernized with advanced assembly-line techniques, causing industrial production to soar. Support for extremist parties has collapsed, proving that our citizens are contented and that the Republic is finally safe."

Article published in a leading German commercial daily newspaper celebrating five years of economic recovery under currency stabilisation, industrial rationalisation, and foreign capital inflows.

HINGE QUESTION: How does Source B's optimistic assessment of German industrial stability directly contradict Stresemann's warning in Source A?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.3

RENTENMARK

Temporary stable currency introduced by Stresemann in Nov 1923, backed by mortgages on German agricultural and industrial land.

DAWES PLAN (1924)

Agreement scaling annual German reparations payments to economic capacity and injecting 800 million gold marks in American loans.

LOCARNO TREATIES (1925)

Pact where Germany voluntarily recognized its western borders with France and Belgium, securing peace in the West.

YOUNG PLAN (1929)

Agreement reducing total German reparations from £6.6bn to £2bn and extending payments over 59 years.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

ACT 3 RESTORING PRIDE: FOREIGN POLICY SUCCESSES

[3.1] Defeat in WWI had made Germany a global outcast. Stresemann used diplomacy—specifically a policy of fulfilling the Treaty of Versailles to build trust—to bring Germany back in from the cold.

- **The Locarno Pact (1925):** Unlike Versailles, this was a treaty Germany signed willingly as an equal partner. Germany agreed to accept its new western borders with France and Belgium, greatly reducing the threat of future war.
- **The League of Nations (1926):** Because of the Locarno Pact, Germany was trusted enough to be invited into the League of Nations. Crucially, they were given a seat on the executive Council, proving Germany was a 'great power' once again.
- **The Kellogg-Briand Pact (1928):** Germany was one of 65 nations to sign this pact, promising never to use war to achieve foreign policy goals.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE LEAGUE OF NATIONS ADDRESS 10 September 1926

Gustav Stresemann's Address to the League of Nations Assembly

"It cannot be the purpose of the League of Nations to measure nations by their military might or the size of their armies. The League must be a fellowship of nations founded upon justice, moral strength, and international cooperation... Germany enters this great assembly with the sincere will to serve peace and to cooperate in solving the great tasks that history has set before mankind."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1878–1929



Gustav Stresemann

CHANCELLOR (1923) AND FOREIGN MINISTER OF GERMANY (1923–1929)

Rescued the Republic from hyperinflation, rebuilt diplomatic relations with the Western Allies, and secured foreign capital to finance German economic recovery.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Ended passive resistance in the Ruhr in September 1923 despite furious right-wing nationalist outcry.
- Introduced the temporary Rentenmark backed by land mortgages, halting hyperinflation and stabilizing the currency.
- Negotiated the Dawes Plan (1924), signed the Locarno Treaties (1925), brought Germany into the League of Nations (1926), and agreed the Young Plan (1929).

ACT 4 EVALUATION: DANCING ON A VOLCANO?

[4.1] Between 1924 and 1929, Germany experienced a 'Golden Age'. Politically, the Republic stabilised. Moderate parties dominated the Reichstag, and extreme parties lost support (the Nazis won just 12 seats in the 1928 election). However, a historian must recognize the fatal flaws hiding beneath the surface:

- **The Quicksand Economy:** Germany's entire recovery was dependent on short-term American loans. If the USA demanded their money back, the German economy would instantly collapse.
- **The Losers of the Golden Age:** Unemployment remained a persistent problem, never dropping below 1.3 million. Furthermore, farmers suffered from plummeting food prices, and the middle classes never got back the life savings they lost in 1923.

Shortly before his sudden death in October 1929, Stresemann himself issued a dark warning: *"The economic position is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is in fact dancing on a volcano."*

FINANCIAL ARCHITECTURE: BORROWED THE DAWES LOAN CYCLE • 1924–1929

The Dawes Plan & "Dancing on a Volcano"

The 1924 Dawes Plan established a circular economic mechanism that temporarily stabilized Europe: American banks loaned billions of dollars to German municipal governments and industrial syndicates; Germany used this influx of capital to rebuild infrastructure, modernize factories, and pay reparations to Britain and France; Britain and France then used these reparation payments to pay off their wartime loans to the United States. While this created a dramatic boom, it created a fatal dependency: German businesses were financed by short-term loans that American financiers could recall on ninety days' notice.

Fatal Dependency: Stresemann himself warned in 1928: *"The economic position is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is dancing on a volcano."* When Wall Street crashed, the entire house of cards collapsed.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE

STRESEMANN: EUROPEAN STATESMAN OR REVISIONIST?

Interpretation A: Multi-Lateral Peacemaker (Jonathan Wright)

"Stresemann was a visionary European statesman who understood that Germany's revival depended on international reconciliation. Locarno and the League represented sincere efforts to integrate Germany into a peaceful West."

Interpretation B: Tactical Nationalist (A.J.P. Taylor)

"Stresemann's 'policy of fulfilment' was merely a shrewd manoeuvre to liberate the Rhineland and dismantle Versailles without war. Meanwhile, funding recovery through fragile US loans left Germany dancing on a financial volcano."

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

ENQUIRY 1.3 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

Identify the two international agreements (1924 and 1929) that restructured German reparations payments. [Recall: Dawes Plan and Young Plan terms]

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS (PEEL):

Explain how the Rentenmark successfully restored public confidence in German currency within weeks. [Use: Backed by mortgage bonds... Supply strictly limited to 3.2bn... Consequently...]

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

'Gustav Stresemann was the saviour of the Weimar Republic.' How far do you agree with this interpretation? [Criteria: Compare diplomatic rehabilitation against economic debt dependency]

KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929

Key Enquiry: A Golden Age or a divided nation: To what extent did the lives of workers, women, and artists genuinely improve during the Weimar Republic's era of recovery? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE STANDARD OF LIVING: DID THINGS IMPROVE?

[1.1] For many ordinary German workers, the years 1924–1929 saw a genuine improvement in their daily lives, largely funded by the Weimar government and American loans.

- **Wages and Work:** The length of the working week decreased, while 'real wages' (the actual purchasing power of a worker's pay) rose by 25% between 1925 and 1928.
- **Unemployment Insurance:** In 1927, the government passed the Unemployment Insurance Act. Workers and employers paid 3% of their wages into a national pot, which provided an average of 60 marks a week in benefits if a worker lost their job or fell ill.
- **Housing:** By 1923, Germany had a massive shortage of one million homes. In 1925, the government introduced a 15% rent tax to fund building associations. Between 1925 and 1929, over 100,000 new homes were built, drastically reducing homelessness.

Evaluation: While industrial workers benefited, the middle classes deeply resented seeing the working classes supported by the state, especially since the middle classes never recovered the savings they lost during the 1923 hyperinflation crisis.

[1.3] The Hidden Economic Burden: War Veterans

Despite improvements in housing and wages for industrial workers, the Weimar government struggled under a massive welfare burden left over from the First World War. Under the **1920 Reich Pension Law**, the state was financially responsible for supporting approximately 2 million war widows, orphans, and disabled veterans. This caused deep resentment across society: the veterans and widows felt the government pensions were never enough to survive on, while taxpayers deeply resented the high taxes required to fund them.

[1.4] Municipal Housing & Progressive Social Welfare:

Between 1924 and 1931, municipal building associations such as GEHAG constructed more than two million high-quality modern homes with electric lighting and indoor plumbing, significantly reducing overcrowding and tuberculosis in working-class districts. In 1927, the Reichstag passed the landmark Unemployment Insurance Act, providing contributory benefits to over 17 million workers—the most comprehensive social safety net in Europe.

SOURCE A OFFICIAL STATISTICAL RECORD

16 July 1927

Reichstag Report on the 1927 Unemployment Insurance Act & War Pensions

"Under the Reich Law of 16 July 1927, compulsory unemployment insurance is established for 17.2 million industrial and clerical workers, funded equally by employers and employees... In addition, the Reich Treasury continues to disburse pensions to 1,537,000 disabled war veterans, 533,000 war widows, and 1,192,000 orphans from the 1914–1918 war."

While the 1927 Act established Europe's most advanced social safety net, the fixed financial burden severely restricted the government's fiscal manoeuvrability when mass unemployment struck in 1929.

HINGE QUESTION: Was the Weimar welfare system a triumph of progressive social justice or an unsustainable economic gamble?

ACT 2 THE CHANGING POSITION OF WOMEN

[2.1] The Weimar Constitution was incredibly progressive. Under **Article 109**, women were granted equal voting rights, the right to enter all professions, and equal pay in the civil service.

WOMEN IN WEIMAR GERMANY: PROGRESS VS THE TRADITIONAL REALITY

POLITICS

Progress: Women over 20 gained the right to vote; by 1926, 32 female deputies sat in the Reichstag—a higher proportion than in Britain or the USA.

Limitation: Zero female cabinet ministers were ever appointed; women rarely held executive leadership in political parties.

WORK

Progress: 100,000 female teachers and 3,000 doctors by 1933; equal civil service pay was enshrined in Article 109.

Limitation: Demobilised men reclaimed better-paid industrial jobs; married working women were attacked as 'double-earners' stealing men's jobs.

LEISURE

Progress: The 'New Woman'—young, financially independent city women with bobbed hair, modern fashion, smoking, and unchaperoned nightlife.

Limitation: Largely a media phenomenon concentrated in Berlin; in rural, traditional communities, patriarchal expectations persisted.

SOURCE B CONSTITUTIONAL CHARTER

11 August 1919

Article 109 of the Weimar Constitution

"All Germans are equal before the law. Men and women have, in principle, the same fundamental civic rights and duties. Marriage is based on the equality of the sexes and the preservation of the family... All exceptional provisions against female civil servants are abolished."

Article 109 established legal equality and women's suffrage for the first time in German history, yet traditional conservative attitudes and economic backlash continued to limit female advancement in practice.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did formal constitutional equality fail to eliminate the social stigma of working women as 'double-earners'?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.4

BAUHAUS

Revolutionary modernist design school founded by Walter Gropius, prioritizing clean functionality: "form follows function".

THE "NEW WOMAN"

Cultural ideal of the modern Weimar woman: financially independent, voting, wearing bobbed hair, and smoking in public.

NEUE SACHLICHKEIT

"New Objectivity"; realist art movement (e.g. Otto Dix, George Grosz) depicting gritty, cynical truths of post-war German society.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

KULTURBOLSCHEWISMUS

"Cultural Bolshevism"; derogatory right-wing label used by nationalists to attack modern art, jazz, and liberated Berlin culture.

ACT 3A CULTURAL EXPLOSION IN THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC

[3.1] In the 1920s, Berlin challenged Paris as the cultural capital of Europe. This explosion of creativity was caused by three things: the end of strict pre-war censorship, the new Weimar Constitution guaranteeing freedom of speech, and economic recovery providing money to fund the arts.

- Art:** Artists like **George Grosz** and **Otto Dix** pioneered the **New Objectivity** movement. Instead of painting beautiful landscapes, they painted the grim reality of Weimar life—disabled war veterans begging on the streets, corrupt politicians, and greedy businessmen.
- Architecture:** **Walter Gropius** founded the **Bauhaus** school of design. They rejected the elaborate, decorative styles of the Kaiser's era. Instead, their slogan was "*Art and Technology - a new unity*," creating buildings and furniture using basic shapes, concrete, and steel.
- Cinema and Nightlife:** The German film industry boomed. Director **Fritz Lang** produced *Metropolis* (1927), a groundbreaking science-fiction film, while **Marlene Dietrich** became a global superstar. Berlin's nightlife became famous for its vibrant, liberal cabaret clubs, jazz bands, and the open acceptance of homosexuality, which had been heavily suppressed under the Kaiser.

ACT 4EVALUATION: A DEEPLY DIVIDED NATION

[4.1] To a top-level historian, the cultural 'Golden Age' was actually a source of severe weakness for the Republic because it deeply divided the nation.

- Left-wing opposition:** The Communists believed government funding for the arts was an extravagant waste of money when ordinary working people were still struggling to buy food.
- Right-wing opposition:** Nationalists, traditionalists, and the Nazi Party were horrified. They believed the new art, the cabaret clubs, and the 'New Woman' were immoral, un-German, and destroying traditional family values. This cultural divide handed the Nazis powerful propaganda weapons to attack the Republic.

Literature and Theatre

The cultural revolution extended into writing and the stage. In 1929, **Erich Maria Remarque** published his highly successful anti-war novel, *All Quiet on the Western Front*, which challenged the right-wing myth that the First World War had been a glorious, heroic struggle. On the stage, directors pioneered *Zeittheater* and *Zeitoper* (theatre and opera of the time), which rejected traditional, historical plays in favour of realistic, highly political performances set in modern times.

PRIMARY PLATEBAUHAUS DESSAU • 1926Architectural Plate

The Bauhaus Complex in Dessau. Designed by Walter Gropius



Gropius designed the Dessau complex with steel frames and continuous glass curtain walls, embodying modern functionalism.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did modern functionalist design provoke such intense hostility from traditional nationalists?

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL1883–1969



Walter Gropius
PIONEER MODERNIST ARCHITECT & FOUNDER OF THE BAUHAUS SCHOOL (1919–1928)

Revolutionized modern architecture and industrial design by uniting fine art with modern industrial technology, creating the iconic Weimar aesthetic.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Founded the Bauhaus in 1919 and designed the iconic glass-and-steel Dessau complex in 1925.
- Pioneered functionalist design ("form follows function"), championing accessible, mass-produced housing and furniture for modern industrial society.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

ENQUIRY 1.4 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:
Identify two social reforms introduced by the Weimar government between 1924 and 1928 to support workers and vulnerable families. [Recall: 1927 Unemployment Insurance Act, municipal housing]

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS (PEEL):
Explain why traditional conservatives and nationalists reacted with such hostility to the emergence of the 'New Woman'. [Use: Challenged traditional family roles... Stigmatised as double-earners...]

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:
'For the vast majority of German citizens, the Golden Twenties brought no real improvement in their daily lives.' To what extent do you agree? [Weigh: Industrial wage rises vs peasant farm debt and middle-class resentment]

KEY TOPIC 1 REVISION SPINE: CORE KNOWLEDGE & EXAM STRATEGY

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1) History • Paper 3 Option 31 (1HI0/31) • Key Topic 1 Synthesis

1. KEY CHRONOLOGY • CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

KEY CHRONOLOGY

28 Oct 1918: Kiel Naval Mutiny: Sailors refuse suicidal attack; sparks nationwide revolution and soldiers' councils.	9 Nov 1918: Abdication of Wilhelm II: Kaiser flees to Holland; Scheidemann proclaims Republic to pre-empt communism.	11 Nov 1918: Armistice Signed: Matthias Erzberger signs surrender at Compiègne; fuels right-wing 'Dolchstoß' myth.
15 Jan 1919: Spartacist Revolt Crushed: Freikorps crush Berlin uprising; Rosa Luxemburg & Karl Liebknecht murdered.	28 Jun 1919: Versailles Treaty Signed: Weimar envoys forced to sign 'Diktat'; loses 13% land, 100k army limit, £6.6bn bill.	11 Aug 1919: Weimar Constitution Enacted: Progressive democracy ratified; introduces Proportional Representation & Article 48.
Mar 1920: The Kapp Putsch: 12,000 Freikorps seize Berlin; army refuses to fire; defeated by general workers' strike.	Jan 1923: Occupation of the Ruhr: 60,000 French/Belgian troops seize industry; passive resistance triggers hyperinflation.	Nov 1923: Rentenmark Currency Reform: Stresemann halts passive resistance; mortgage-backed currency restores stability.
Aug 1924: The Dawes Plan: Scales reparations to capacity; US banks loan 800m gold marks to revive German industry.	Oct 1925: The Locarno Treaties: Germany voluntarily accepts western borders with France/Belgium; secures European peace.	Sep 1926: League of Nations Entry: Germany admitted to League Council as a permanent Great Power; ends diplomatic isolation.

2. CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES

SPECIFICATION REVIEW

I. CONSTITUTIONAL FLAWS Pure Proportional Representation (1 seat per 60k votes) prevented majorities, producing 20 fragile coalitions in 14 years. Article 48 allowed the President to rule by decree, creating a fatal dictatorial loophole.	II. EXTREMIST VIOLENCE Right-wing Dolchstoß myth branded republicans "November Criminals". Armed coups from left (Spartacists 1919) and right (Kapp 1920, Munich 1923) exposed state dependence on unloyal imperial soldiers.	III. ECONOMIC RECOVERY Halting passive resistance and issuing the Rentenmark halted hyperinflation. Dawes (1924) & Young (1929) Plans rebuilt industry on American credit—creating what Stresemann called "dancing on a volcano".	IV. CULTURAL POLARIZATION Abolishing censorship unleashed avant-garde Bauhaus design, cinema, and the liberated "New Woman". However, provincial conservatives fiercely condemned Berlin culture as "cultural Bolshevism".
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3. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY

EXAM STRATEGY • Q3(B,C,D)

INTERPRETATION 1: THE DOOMED REPUBLIC (KOLB / PEUKERT) Weimar democracy was mortally wounded at birth by Versailles, Article 48, and unrepentant imperial civil servants and judges who subverted democracy. Stresemann's prosperity was an artificial bubble built on volatile US loans that inevitably burst in 1929.		INTERPRETATION 2: THE RESILIENT GOLDEN AGE (EVANS / BOOKBINDER) Between 1924 and 1929, the Republic demonstrated remarkable resilience, weathering revolutionary coups and hyperinflation to build modern housing, progressive welfare, and peaceful diplomatic integration. Extremist votes collapsed to just 2.6% in 1928.		
Q1: INFERENCE [4m] 5 Mins • 2 Inferences + Quotes	Q2: CAUSATION [12m] 15 Mins • 3 PEEL Causal Factors	Q3(a): UTILITY [8m] 12 Mins • Content, NOP & Context	Q3(b/c): VIEWS [8m] 10 Mins • Differences & Reasons	Q3(d): VERDICT [16+4m] 25 Mins • Balanced Evaluation

4. SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT • HISTORICAL VERDICT

EVALUATION & SIGNIFICANCE

DEMOCRACY ON TRIAL: The Republic demonstrated surprising resilience in overcoming the 1919–1923 existential crises. By 1928, moderate coalition parties won 73% of the vote, and political assassinations had ceased. However, PR prevented stable parliamentary majorities, and Article 48 established a fatal habit of executive rule.	ECONOMIC ILLUSION: Industrial output surpassed 1913 levels by 1928, and real wages rose steadily. Yet prosperity was an illusion financed by volatile American short-term loans. When Gustav Stresemann warned that Germany was "dancing on a volcano", he correctly foresaw that any US credit contraction would trigger catastrophic collapse.	SOCIAL & DIPLOMATIC LEGACY: The Locarno Treaties and entry into the League of Nations restored Germany's great power status without firing a single shot. However, the psychological trauma of 1923 hyperinflation and conservative fury against modern Berlin culture left deep societal divisions that right-wing extremists would readily exploit.
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5. INTERACTIVE QUIZZING HUB • SCAN WITH SMARTPHONE CAMERA

20-QUESTION PRACTICE QUIZZES

KT 1.1 Origins of Republic  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT 1.2 Early Challenges 1919–23  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT 1.3 Recovery 1924–29  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT 1.4 Society & Culture  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ
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